
PHILOSOPHY, METAPHYSICS, DEMOCRACY

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PHILOSOPHY, METAPHYSICS, DEMOCRACY

Gianni Vattimo

We confront the problem of the relationship between philosophy and politics at a moment which, at least in my opinion, is characterized by two “epochal” events with all the risks which the use of that term entails. On the one hand, philosophy has lived through, and is still living through, that process which Heidegger called the “end of metaphysics”: namely, the dissolution of the pretenses of foundational thought, the so-called “crisis of reason”—which, although perhaps over-emphasized or reduced to a generic slogan, is a fact that is difficult to ignore. On the other hand, on the side of politics, the fall of real socialism has cast a pall of discredit over ideological politics of a “deductive” or global kind, leaving behind a largely “Popperian” liberalism, which endeavors to think the political pragmatically in terms of small steps, or trial and error.¹ Even if there is no causal connection between the one and the other, these two events are obviously connected. Already before the fall of real socialism, the crisis of metaphysics (in the Heideggerian sense) had also developed in connection with the waning of the political conditions for a universalistic thought: for instance, the end of colonialism, the emerging voice of other cultures and the parallel emergence of cultural anthropology, or the discrediting of the myth of a unilinear progress of humanity, guided by the most civilized West. (This crisis, too, was “practical” before it was “theoretical”; witness the first world war.)

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If this summary is the broadest horizon—a sort of “Prologue in Heaven”² for our current situation—at a level closer to home the crisis of the political parties (not only those which have been destroyed by endemic corruption, but also those that have seen their vitality reduced to a minimum by the increasing TV-dependence [*tele-dipendenza*] of a large part of their traditional public) also bears the signs of a drastic change in the relationship between philosophy and politics.³ The “organic intellectual” has lost his/her role and legitimacy, first of all due to the fact that Marxist communism has ended, and second, because the figure of the intellectual has lost its interlocutor—namely, the political party.⁴ Though in many cases this interlocutor has been resurrected in the generic form of ‘public opinion’ witness the many among us who, within the academy, practice the trade of commentator, columnist, or editorialist—it would be difficult to assert that there is a real political role for the intellectual. The condition in which he or she operates in this function as a journalist (who can hardly be called ‘specialist’ or ‘expert,’ and who bears the marks of the “intellectual” in the Gramscian sense of the word) is even marked by his or her freedom from political influence. This position is rather more akin to the role of the creative artist, whose relationship with social and political reality is, however, always mediated by the workings of the “marketplace” (however neutral or free it may be).

This aspect of the problem might appear marginal, but it is not. The relationship of the philosopher to the political is most certainly, perhaps above all, a problem of content, of “what” the philosopher has to say to the politician. However, the content of “what” the philosopher has to say is profoundly marked by the conditions in which it is elaborated and formulated. The difference which, at least up until a few years ago, we regularly observed between the public presence (e.g., in the media) of philosophy in Italy and in the Anglo-Saxon world, for example, has always seemed linked to the fact that in Italy philosophy has been, since the Gentile reform, an important teaching material for high-schools.⁵ I recall this fact only in order to point out that, in speaking of philosophy and politics, we ought to

pay close attention to the prevailing conditions under which those who practice philosophy in our societies work and live, with particular concern precisely for the place of philosophy in schools (which, I believe, ought to be expanded well beyond its current limits).

The two "macro-events" to which I alluded at the outset create a double condition—a difficulty and an opening—for the relationship between the philosopher and the politician which, it seems to me, merits attention. The parallel, and connected, dissolution of metaphysics and of real socialism combine definitively to put an end to the epoch of the philosopher as "advisor to the prince"—whether we are speaking of the enlightened sovereign of the seventeenth-century *philosophes*, or whether we are speaking of the political party, the "new" Gramscian "prince."⁶ Not, however, because the philosopher is now replaced by the scientist or economist according to a logic of progress. If this were the case, the traditional relationship between the philosopher and the politician would remain unchanged, save for the replacement of one type of advisor (obsolete because no longer specialized) with another. Rather, the end of metaphysics, in politics, really corresponds to the affirmation of democracy. Philosophy, as far as it is concerned, discovers that reality does not allow itself to be comprehended in a compact, logical system which would be applicable to political choices. Politics, for its part, experiences its own inability to conform to the "truth," since it must instead let itself be guided by the flux of minorities and majorities, by the democratic consensus. (It is important to underline this separation between politics and truth. In Italy, and in the Catholic world, we find ourselves constantly provoked by the request to make the laws of the State conform to that which the Church considers metaphysical "truth": human nature, the Good, the Just and so forth.)

Naturally, a politics without "truth" is not necessarily a democratic politics. It can also be despotic, which instead of going beyond metaphysics takes a step backwards with regard to the discovery of, and demand for, human rights (a demand which is, of course,

itself metaphysically inspired). Departing above all from this concern with democracy, and with an awareness of the absolute impossibility of founding a rational politics on philosophy, it seems to me that there emerge today those political philosophies which concentrate on the philosophical legitimation of democracy, or the free state in general.⁷ I do not wish to discuss here whether positions like those of Habermas or Apel can also develop beyond the legitimation of democracy, and in the direction of substantive choices in favor of this or that political system, or of this or that particular model of society and state. Whatever answer one gives to these questions, it is fairly clear that such positions remain within a model we might call traditional—that is, “philosophical-political.” They derive from a philosophical reflection on the conditions of possibility for every sensible discourse; namely, the need, or obligation, to construct democratic societies, whence, in the very end, the performative contradiction which is the *passe partout* above all of Apel, but also of the Habermasian theory of communicative action. It should be quite obvious that I’m not objecting to the acceptability of the political conclusions at which, by different paths, Habermas and Apel arrive. However, it seems to me that a certain sense of political “futility” in their discourse—by which I mean its being confined to the academy, to a circle of specialists, and in a moment in which the legitimacy of liberal democracy goes practically uncontested—depends also upon its inability truly to place itself within the new condition of philosophy. (And not only within “political philosophy,” which I believe ought to recognize the ways in which it is deeply marked by democracy, over and beyond discourses of legitimation which are still carried out from an essentialist or transcendental point of view.)

Whether it wants to present itself as a theory which legitimizes a certain form of state, or whether it instead intends to promote more substantive and specific political choices, philosophy today ought not to speak any longer from a foundational point of view. If philosophy works from this perspective, even if only implicitly, it exposes itself to the consequence of having to make its political efficacy depend upon some form of authoritarianism; it must ally itself with a “prince.” As evidence of this, consider the Habermasian and Apelian

idea of an unimpeded social communication, and the resulting, persistent suspicion about the dominant classes' manipulation of the voters through the use of the mass-media, because of which the response at the polls would always be, to varying degrees, vexed because not truly free. Such a suspicion can certainly be valid as a regulative ideal in order to move [*orientare*] the laws closer to an always more perfect realization of the freedom of the press, and thus closer to the struggles against information-monopolies and so forth. But this move also always presupposes, in a radical way, the connection between politics and truth, and therefore the risk of having to submit to a certain mandarin [*mandarinato*] form, to whom or to which the job of policing the transparency of communication is entrusted.

Therefore it seems that, beyond the consideration of the specific circumstances in which the relationship between philosophy and politics (the media society, the problem of philosophy in schools, the dissolution of political parties, etc.) is settled today, the principal question to which we ought to try to respond is: what is left of the political-philosophical relationship in a world in which, whether as a result of the end of metaphysics, or as a consequence of the affirmation of democracy, one can no longer think the political in terms of truth? The double condition, of difficulty and of opening, in which philosophy comes to find itself in this world results from the fact that, on the one hand, it can no longer offer politics directives extracted from its knowledge of essences, foundations, or conditions of possibility. On the other hand, since it no longer has to, or no longer can, be the thought of foundations, philosophy intrinsically becomes political thought, whose form I propose we call "ontology of actuality."⁸ I have tried to clarify elsewhere what this expression, taken freely from the late Foucault, means.⁹

Very summarily, this philosophy conceives of itself as the (most persuasive) answer to the Heideggerian call to commemorate [*rammemorare*] Being.¹⁰ In *Being and Time* this call was not formulated in the name of some abstract need for cognitive completion (a fundamental ontology is required in order to found regional ontologies; Husserl in the *Krisis* starts again from this point), but rather in

reaction to the fragmentation of experience and of the very notion of reality which is produced in and by modernity. It is above all with the “Weberian” modernity—characterized by specialization, the separation of the spheres of existence and value, and by the multiplication of sectarian languages—that the memory of what “Being” means is lost. On the other hand, since the outcome of Heidegger’s reflection leads to the recognition that Being is not there—but rather that it happens, and therefore we cannot recover [*risalire*] an object which makes itself present—to commemorate Being will mean (for those who want to interpret Heidegger even against certain self-misunderstandings of his own) to struggle to understand what “Being” means in our actual experience.

On this basis, it is hardly shocking [*scandaloso*] to maintain that a commemorative thought [*Andenkend*]¹—which is what Heidegger believes non- or post-metaphysical thought must be—can also be defined as democratic thought. What this thought listens to, in its attempt to commemorate, are not only the archaic and mysterious originary voices which would be lost in the tumultuous growth of modernity; there is no origin placed somewhere outside the actuality of the event. There is the depth [*spessore*] of the event which, while it certainly brings with it the traces of the past, is nevertheless composed of the voices of the present. The past itself is something we approach only through that which, of the past, remains conserved until our time, its *Wirkungsgeschichte*.

Can a philosophy which has taken leave of the illusion of a foundation really continue to call itself ontology? It is well-known that a few interpreters and virulent prosecutors [*prosecutori radicali*] of Heidegger, foremost among them Derrida, deny that Being can still be spoken of, because this would be to fall back within foundational metaphysics. Yet, to continue to speak of Being and ontology is not an excessive pretense [*pretesa*]. Rather, it is an expression of the modesty of this philosophy. It knows that it does not have to respond to the “truth,” but only to the need for a re-composition of experience for an historical humanity which is living through the fragmentation of the division of labor, the specialization of languages, and the many forms of discontinuity to which the rapid transformations of our world, which are above all technological, expose us.

Being can only be put aside if, by doing so, one means to respond to a more objective truth of things, a truth which would then emerge precisely through the exclusion of Being as a “pretense” [*finzione*].

Defined as “ontology of actuality,” philosophy is put into practice as an interpretation of the epoch, which gives form to a diffused feeling about the sense of actual existence in a certain society and in a certain historical world. I am aware that this may seem like re-inventing the wheel—making philosophy the spirit-of-the-times, Hegelian memory. The difference is in the word “interpretation.” Philosophy is not an expression of the epoch; it is an interpretation, which of course tries hard to be persuasive, but which recognizes its own contingency, freedom, and risk. Not only does Hegel seem to return, but empiricism plays a part as well. The epoch—and the general, diffused feeling about its meaning—is perhaps only “experience,” to which the empiricists struggle to be faithful. Experience interpreted philosophically: that which is interpreted with the tools of, and in continuity with, a certain textual tradition—of which certain elements, aspects, and authors are chosen rather than others—but which remains present as a background in its totality, as a possible source of alternative interpretations.

However this proposal is taken, it should at least be clear that it configures an alternative to the philosophies which continue to see themselves, as far as the political is concerned, as providing a foundational function (or even just the transcendental legitimation of a certain form of government, independently of the specific choices which will be made according to the rules of the game). Leaving aside every foundational pretense, an “ontology of actuality” offers to the political a certain vision of the historical process in progress and a certain free, and risky, interpretation of its positive potential—a potential judged such not on the basis of eternal principles, but on the basis of argued choices made from within the process itself (we already know, more or less, what’s best).¹¹ As is well-known Richard Rorty has spoken of a Kantian *lignée* and a Hegelian *lignée* which oppose each other in today’s thought. Well, here we are obviously following a Hegelian line, in the sense that philosophy takes seriously its responsibility to engage with history; it bets upon certain developments rather than others, and therefore abandons its position of

transcendental neutrality—a position to which the explicit return of Kant (read Apel and Habermas) and a large part of analytical political thought remain linked.

However, an ontology of actuality, when it forces itself to pass from programmatic enunciation to concrete elaboration, finds this passage no easier than foundational philosophy does. On the contrary, the task becomes more difficult still because, to return to the initial considerations, the social and professional conditions of its practice are still above all modeled after the academic figure of the traditional philosopher, or perhaps the scientist or specialist, called in to unearth with rigor a certain tiny portion of the vast world of knowledge. If one adds the fact that, with the dissolution of the political parties and the general weariness of political associationism, any possible augmentation of the philosopher's social position has almost disappeared, it will be understood that the philosopher's attempt to give form to the diffused feeling, to democratically "represent" in some measure the actual sense of Being, brings with it almost insurmountable difficulties. Thus the distance between philosophy—even in the form I propose which, at least in principle, should be more open to dialogue with the political—and the political remains immense. But even if the reflection on philosophy and politics from my point of view doesn't help to provide a new perspective on the philosophical contribution to politics, it can at least serve to recall philosophy to a more radical awareness of what the event of the end of metaphysics (if there is such a thing), and the advent of democracy in thought, signify.

Translated by Paul Kottman

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- 1 [TN. "Popperiano," a reference to the epistemological philosopher Karl Raimond Popper.]
 - 2 [TN. "prologo in cielo" is an allusion to Goethe's *Faust*, "Prolog in Himmel."]
 - 3 [TN. Italian politics has recently witnessed the dissolution of many of its political parties. Unlike the two-party system in the United States, until recently there was a wide spectrum of political parties in Italy among which votes were more or less evenly divided.]
 - 4 [TN. "Intellettuale organico" is a phrase taken from Antonio Gramsci.]
 - 5 [TN. The "Gentile" reform refers to sweeping changes in the Italian educational system which were instigated by Gentile in 1929. In Italy, philosophy plays a much greater role in high-school education than it does in the United States. Likewise, philosophers enjoy a public visibility through the media in Italy, something which is much less true in the United States.]
 - 6 [TN. Again, this is a reference to Gramsci's "nuovo principe."]
 - 7 I am thinking for example of the recent *Facts and Norms* by Jürgen Habermas.
 - 8 [TN. The Italian for this phrase is "ontologia dell'attualità."]
 - 9 Allow me to refer here to my other writings on the same theme, for example: *La società trasparente* (Milano: Garzanti, 1989), trans. into English as *The Transparent Society* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1992), and "Ontologia dell'attualità," in *Filosofia* 87, ed. Gianni Vattimo (Rome: Laterza, 1988).
 - 10 [TN. For a longer discussion of "commemoration" in relation to Heidegger, see the essays on Heidegger in Vattimo's *The End of Modernity*, trans. Jon Snyder (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1988).]
 - 11 For more on the tendency of much of twentieth-century philosophy to present itself as a reflection of the epoch, even to configure itself as a sort of "sociological impression," see my essay: "Postmoderno, tecnologia, ontologia," in *Micromega* (1990), fasc. 4.